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"Projecting" the Future: a Discourse on Quality as a Pivotal Entry Variable in Planning International Development Projects

ABSTRACT

As instruments of change, projects, when implemented thoughtfully and functionally, have the capacity to improve lives and be economically transformative to serve the greater good and contribute to creating a future we all can believe in. The pressure on the academic community, and in particular project management domain, to achieve and demonstrate more impact, bridge theory and practice, and solve practical problems relating to project ineffectuality and failure, especially those in development contexts, is thus mounting. Foresight is more valuable than hindsight. Thus, the potential to rethink feasible paradigms critical to futureproofing projects to boost their impact to advance transformative and sustainable development is retrospectively alluring from a practitioner's perspective. Real options to influence the final project outcome are said to be at the highest at the front-end. Hence, considering the significant mix of unruly VUCA in today's environment and to contribute to the discussion on projects and society, this paper moots and makes a clarion call for a rethink of project planning to adopt the heretofore overlooked Quality-at-Entry (QAE) variable to design battle-ready projects for implementation. The paper proposes ways in which a compendium of research needful to advance a comprehensive understanding and exploitation of QAE could be achieved.

Keywords: Global South, Projects and society, Project management in international development, Project-as-practice, Quality-at-Entry, Research-as-practice

1. INTRODUCTION

A significant mix of unruly volatility, uncertainty, complexity, and ambiguity (VUCA) characterises the business environment today. This is particularly true of the "Global South" or "Third World" environment and presents further acute challenges for functional management (see, e.g., [1]). The "Global South" or "Third World" (or development economies - as used interchangeably in this paper) functions more than a metaphor for underdevelopment to broadly refer to the regions of Latin America, Asia, Africa, and Oceania mostly characterised by low income and often political or cultural marginalisation (see [2]). Much has thus changed and continues to change in the current era as significant known knowns, known unknowns, and unknown unknowns continue to evolve the business and development landscape into nothing we have ever witnessed. Such VUCAlity, accelerated by e.g., climate change and the unprecedented on-going, all-encompassing, and unfolding COVID-19 pandemic destroying numerous accustomed society systems and operations to impact every facet of our lives as it rages on, is changing society and people's lives at a fast pace. Uncertainty has thus become the only certainty. In effect, VUCAlity on the one hand, is bound to have an impact on almost everything from the way products, services, processes, and systems are developed; how research and development are organised; and how innovation[1] is managed (see, e.g., [3]). On the other hand, it would give rise to many never-experienced projects as we

1 Innovation, used here, refers to both the process of producing an output and the output itself.

seek to stabilise and move our society forward without compromising the life of future generations.

Projects are recognised as processes or strategies through which human, financial and material resources are organised in a novel way to undertake a unique scope of work of given specifications within the constraints of cost and time to achieve beneficial change as defined by quantitative and qualitative objectives (cf. [4]). Thus viewed, projects are, by definition, all about creating change. As a result, projects have become inevitable to connecting today to tomorrow. They are therefore indispensable to changing society and individual lives, especially in the holistic multidisciplinary and multibillion international development (ID) sector, which has been instrumental to addressing relevant, fast-changing, and complex global challenges of our time relating to climate change, poverty reduction and promoting human rights, to mention but a few. Therein lies one useful utility of projects and their connection to development - a process of creating and delivering change. Because of such utility and advantages of the "project concept" including but not limited to ensuring and leading sustainability (e.g., [5]) and judicious use of resources through special emphasis and action, the process of development of products, services and systems, research, innovation1, and development all leverage the "project concept" in the quest to deliver value, and transformative and sustainable change and development.

Human as we are, we are not necessarily good with change. Hence, the connection between projects and development renders the stakes and pressure for projects much higher now than ever before. This has generated profound consequences for the field and profession of project management (PM). This is because owing to the significant mix of unruly VUCA, we are now in an era where projects, but particularly so those in development contexts, should not only be about outputs. They ought to also be about outcomes, which would hopefully produce or translate into benefits that could, with time, generate needful ubiquitous value and impact to advance change and durable development within the "Global South" and beyond. Thus, sustainable development, which has become one of the most important challenges and concerns of our time as evident in the adoption of the 17 interlinked global sustainable development goals (SDGs) designed to be a blueprint to achieve a better and more sustainable future for all, is within the purview of projects and PM. This further makes projects and PM even more invaluable and paramount to channelling and achieving transformative and sustainable development especially in the "Global South".

Howbeit, the reality is that project ineffectuality and failure is not confined to the past. As a result, the reputation of PM with most people is that projects are generally dud undertakings (e.g., [6]). This hard truth is perhaps even more alarming and challenging in project operations in ID cooperation (see [7]), herein referred to as ID projects. We cannot gloss over the fact that such projects have played an outsized role in poverty reduction and promoting shared prosperity and durable development for several decades and hence, tend to be in the highest echelon of the modalities for leading and sustaining transformative change and development in developing economies. Yet, ample rich PM in ID literature (e.g., [1]; [8]; [9]; [10]) suggests patchy (performance) outcomes that mirror failure on the part of such development projects to deliver on their promise. Even when and where they manage to succeed, Boakye and Liu [11] has averred that they usually produce momentary and fragmented impact. Such outcomes affect the impact of key development agenda to generate profound ramifications on individuals, societies, and economies alike.

Consequently, it seems safe to submit that poor performance and failure are classic vignettes of contemporary ID projects. Unfortunately, many challenges to effective PM in developing economies, including but not limited to poor resource availability and perhaps, weak knowledge base in the discipline (e.g., [12]) alongside significant VUCAlity of the present-day environment are afoot. Hence, the ID sector cannot seem to find the wood in the trees when it comes to addressing the issue of ineffectuality and failure of its project operations. The result is that ID projects still fail and continue to disappoint in delivering needful value and impact. Such outcome reverberates for many years to influence key sectoral, national, regional, and global sustainable development agenda. Consequently, one key question still looms large - how can projects upscale their mandate to deliver value and impact which could enable and sustain durable development in the "new now" and the future?

2. REDRESSING THE CHALLENGE

Today, it does not stretch the boundaries of validity to submit that ineffectuality and failure of ID projects, in many ways, represent a dark vortex in assuring transformative change and sustainable development of society. Such dark vortex is an intersection where poor PM strategies and practices, and contemporary significant mix of unruly VUCA and its profound effect on management come into play to generate consistent drawbacks in the creation and delivery of value and impact by such project systems. There is therefore the need for PM in ID cooperation to rethink how to create a win-win situation for the stakeholder-beneficiary dyad. This is because any PM strategy that could provide potentially significant opportunities for controlling the challenges that prevent functional design, implementation, and delivery of ID projects to boost their effectiveness and put failure into check, no matter how small the effect size, would generate great strides towards improved value creation and impact generation. Such effect could significantly make a key contribution to advancing transformative change and sustainable development efforts.

Such rethinking has become needful because we, as humans, are not invincible to VUCAlity no matter how good we are. Further, the project planning process, no matter how lengthy and elaborate it might be, is equally not invincible to VUCAlity. It thus behoves PM professionals in ID to strive to always set the right tone at the project outset. Indeed, the challenges to setting such tone might be enormous considering the extent of VUCAlity in the contemporary business and development environment, but particularly so that of the "Third World". That notwithstanding, a cogent answer or part thereof could emanate from re-engaging quality as an important measure of development during front-end loading of ID projects. That way, we could rethink how to generate ID project systems that integrate the best of human abilities, insights, and perspectives to make them battle-ready. This would go a long way to enable them to contain the shocks of VUCAlity and thrive to deliver improved (performance) outcomes to generate adequate impact to move society forward towards a sustainable direction. Besides, research (e.g., [10]; [13]; [14]; [15]) consistently reveal that poor planning is a common reason for ineffectuality and failure of ID projects. This ultimately supports the credence that the problem of project failure is in a project system that is almost certainly doomed to fail from the outset (see, e.g., [16]; [17]).

Considering these, it is safe to propound that the quality of the ID project (management) plan is essential to improved and effective implementation and delivery of the project as well as the overall outcome and impact of the project. After all, in its most common parlance, quality refers to the degree of fitness of an endeavour for operationalisation. Moreover, project planning, which is done with limited information at the outset, provides a mere structure that might not be followed to its entirety in implementing and delivering the project in the unknowable future. Such unknowable future, as explained by the Project Studies Group of Copenhagen Business School[2], becomes a dilemma and challenge when PM is expected to act as if they know the future - as if PM professionals are super humans. Such dilemma and challenge are fundamental prerequisites for the ID and conventional project system. Hence, the quality infused into the ID project system at the front-end along the elements of e.g., relevance, effectiveness, impact, and sustainability ought to be the project's first line of offense to effectiveness, not a last line of defense. At first glance, this might seem overly optimistic. But through further thinking and inspection, we would find that early-stage quality assurance in ID projects would be quite useful to dismantling barriers to effective project delivery as well as to maximising the value that stand to be created. This is because quality is about excellence; degree of fit and innately linked to satisfac-

2 Please see https://www.cbs.dk/en/research/departments-and-centres/department-of-organization/centres-and-groups/procon-project-studies-group

tion and approval. Hence, early-stage quality assurance or engagement in ID project systems seems the most obvious step to take to futureproof projects and guard against poor project (performance) outcomes and failure as well as insignificant value and impact generation.

In consequence, whatever justification or argument put forth for poor project performance (outcomes), failure as well as insignificant and unsustainable impact generation by ID projects, the overriding issue has to do with the quality embedded into the fundamental design of the project system at the front-end. This is because quality is never an accident but the result of high intention, sincere effort, and intelligent direction, which ought to be caused or constructed into project systems early enough to enable desired and/or appropriate results. As a result, Kerzner [18] suggested that any project that seeks quality must properly plan for that quality at the project outset. This renders quality as a pivotal entry variable in planning ID projects to single out the emergent quality-at-entry (QAE) variable[3] to put it into perspective. Such utility of QAE perhaps explains why Boakye [19] described the nascent variable as a cogent early-stage barometer of project health after identifying it as a critical underlying reason why ID projects fail. It therefore makes sense that the variable is the foundation on which successful project implementation and delivery are built in practice. QAE has thus become a prime determinant of successful development outcomes and used as an additional condition to facilitate satisfactory (performance) outcomes of development project operations of numerous multi-lateral development banks. It is worth noting here that little evidence exists from this perspective, which presents opportunities for academic research.

Further, scattered, and limited evidence in academia (e.g., [20]; [21]; [22]) evinces QAE as a possible resource for boosting effectiveness and overall successful outcomes of development projects. Such evidence also presents further opportunities for studies aimed at generating an all-encompassing understanding of the variable to facilitate its utility and exploitation to advance the theory and practice of PM. Yet, academic research on QAE is strikingly limited. It is therefore ambiguous with a blurry understanding, a blurriness that means almost everything relating to aspects or requirements or indicators of ID projects are ultimately considered to be QAE. QAE thus begs for clarity. Additionally, Kfouri [23] has pointed out that QAE has been used in academic literature to reference technical rigor, client engagement, environmental and social sustainability. Yet, a systematic, replicable, and measurable set of predictive metrics to define the variable hardly exist [23] although evidence supports the hypothesis that the use of a checklist could be an effective framework for assessing QAE in efforts to improve project (performance) outcomes (see [22]). This presents further research opportunities to, on the one hand, generate a comprehensive understanding of the variable and on the other hand, develop a sound QAE frame of reference that could facilitate quality engagement and assurance right at the ID project outset. This has the capacity to aid effective project implementation and delivery to, in turn, help to maximise the value and impact such create.

3. OVERVIEW TO QAE IN DEVELOPMENT PRACTICE

To date, Quality-at-Entry (QAE) continues to be an important operational consideration for many development institutions, including multi-lateral development banks such as the World Bank and African Development Bank (AfDB) Groups. Hence, major reforms including but not limited to human resource augmentation and decentralization, and covenants, which have the potential to substantially influence QAE, have been initiated for development interventions that depend on stakeholder participation to achieve results. Owing to such importance, both uni- and multi-lateral development banks have created quality divisions, such as the Quality Assurance and Results Department (QRQR) of the AfDB Group and the Quality Assurance Group (QAG) of World Bank Group. The activities of these divisions are directly targeted at improving the QAE of projects of the institutions.

Some available literature that has reported on the effect of QAE in development project systems suggests

3 I use the term variable since QAE is a non-consistent factor that could be adapted to suit various project types and settings.

a positive impact on the (performance) outcomes of ID projects. For e.g., reporting on a statistical work undertaken by the World Bank Group's independent evaluation office, Morra and Thumm ([24]), as summarised in Table 1 below, evinced a strong correlation between sound QAE and satisfactory development outcomes.

Table 1: Quality at entry and development outcomes in World Bank projects (n=1125)

	Unsuccessful (%)	Satisfactory Outcomes (%)
Adequate quality at entry	20	80
Inadequate quality at entry	65	35

Source: Morra & Thumm (1997)

Cui and Olsson ([25]) also studied and reported on the Finance Ministry of Norway's QAE regime, which was initially introduced and implemented in the year 2000 in efforts to avoid cost overrun and facilitate project success. They report that the regime was used to regulate mandatory quality assurance and uncertainty analysis of all large government projects whose budget exceeded NOK 500 million prior to their appropriation by parliament. In investigating the effects of the scheme, Magnussen and Samset [21] and Olsson et al.'s [26] studies point to an increased awareness about cost estimates of major government projects and issues that affect project success. This according to those studies led to providing some sort of a "second opinion" on projects as well as an improved decision basis before projects are submitted to parliament for approval.

Further, a review of a report on some project operations of the AfDB Group in Ghana confirms the utility and importance of the QAE variable to improved project (performance) outcomes to generate two insights. First, there exists a direct positive relationship between sound project QAE and satisfactory project outcomes as hinted by Morra and Thumm ([24]). Analysis of the report reveals those projects of the AfDB Group in its development assistance operations to the Ghanaian agriculture and rural development sector from 1997 to 2001, which had poor QAE illustrated through, e.g., inadequate preparation, and appraisal and design, all resulted in unsatisfactory performance outcomes. All the first-generation projects (earlier projects from 1973-1983) of the Bank Group that had a poor QAE such as the Nasia Rice Project, Cotton Production Project and Palm Oil Milling Factories Project all generated unsatisfactory outcomes as Table 2 depicts. However, its second and third generation projects such as the Agriculture Sector Rehabilitation Programme as well as subsequent projects like Food Crops Development Project, which had somewhat sound QAE, all achieved satisfactory development outcomes as evident from Table 2.

Table 2: Quality at Entry and project outcome rating scores[4] of sampled AfDB projects

Name of Project	Scores	
	Relevance & QAE	Outcome Rating
Nasia Rice Project	2	1
Cotton Production Project	2	1
Palm Oil Milling Factories Project	2	1

4 Project Outcome Rating Score is a measure the AfDB Group uses to assess the performance of its projects. The Outcome Rating Score, which gives an indication of project performance, is the average measure of a project that takes into consideration, relevance, efficacy, and efficiency of the project. Ratings are on a four-point scale of 1 to 4 where 1 indicates a highly unsatisfactory performance and 4, highly satisfactory performance.

First Line of Credit (LOC I)	3	3
Subri Industrial Plantation Project	3	3
Second Line of Credit (LOC II)	3	3
Agricultural Sector Rehabilitation Programme	3	3
Women in Community Development	2	2
Third Line of Credit (LOC III)	3	3
Food Crops Development Project	3	3

Source: Ghana: Review of bank assistance to the agriculture and rural development sector, 1997-2001 report

Second, the review of the report also suggests that projects with poor QAE mostly suffer from challenges such as implementation delays, which facilitate cost and time overruns. Such projects often lack innovation1, become distressed and often simply fail. For e.g., Nasia Rice Project, which had a rather low relevance and QAE score of 2 (Table 2), suffered from a seven (7)-month implementation delay, which led to a time overrun of approximately three (3) and a half years, i.e., 42 months. This suggests a plausible effect of QAE on effective implementation and delivery of developments projects, which cannot be overemphasised.

4. CALL TO RESEARCH

Indeed, the temporality of projects is not logically compatible with the concept of sustainable development, which the United Nations World Commission on Environment and Development explains as a process of change in which the exploitation of resources, the direction of investments, the orientation of technological development and institutional change are all in harmony and enhance both current and future potential to meet human needs and aspirations (cf. [27]). Howbeit, as instruments of change, projects connect today to tomorrow. Such change is equally a theme of sustainable development. This goes to show that development towards a sustainable society, which requires change (see [27]) equally requires projects to effect and lead that change. Hence, at a time when our current usage of natural resources, estimated at 1.5 to 1.6 times of earth's annual biocapacity, has become unsustainable [27], the relevance of ID projects to sustainable development, and consideration of sustainable development principles in ID projects vice versa cannot be overemphasised. This means that designed, implemented, and administered thoughtfully and functionally, ID projects have the capacity to improve lives and be economically transformative. Such change and transformation have the capacity to serve the greater good and push society towards shared sustainable prosperity and development. This accord development projects a vital leadership role in contributing to sustainable development of organisations and society, and the SDGs at large (e.g., [27]; [28]; [29]).

From the evidence presented herein, which is by no means meant to be exhaustive, QAE could well be the lynchpin of front-end quality assurance, functional implementation and delivery and improved outcome of ID projects. Hence, understanding the inhibitors, drivers and dynamics that underpin sound QAE in ID projects might be a boon for the multibillion ID sector since they could of tremendous importance to realising robust PM systems capable of delivering more value and impact to advance development. However, contemporary PM research have failed to investigate such inhibitors, drivers, and dynamics. The time has therefore never been right for a compendium of research-as-practice studies on the budding QAE variable. Research-as-practice, herein used, refers to rigorous, exploitable, theoretically underpinned, and practice-oriented research, which is accessible for business and development and can generate a positive impact on society. Such research studies ought to be set in a project-as-practice (see [30]) and scholar-practitioner context to generate requisite insights and perspectives to inform and advance our understanding of QAE to maximise its exploitation in PM in ID practice. This could, for e.g., be achieved through research inquires, which seek to, inter alia:

1. Generate an all-encompassing definition of QAE and explore potential quality-inhibiting factors at

the project front-end. Such research focus could help to proffer what could be done to redress quality assurance drawbacks at the project front-end and generate useful considerations essential to assuring sound QAE in ID project development.

2. Investigate the mediating effect of QAE on project performance and outcome as well as any plausible mediating roles of QAE metrics on same.

3. Frame a streamlined theoretical and practice oriented QAE frame of reference of direct and indirect influence on ID project systems. Such framework could serve as an enabler to enhance the effectiveness of ID projects in implementation and delivery to maximise the value and impact they create to, in turn, advance development efforts.

Through such inquiries, academic research stands to generate evidence and knowledge to inform critical considerations on key quality perspectives at the project front-end. This could in turn lead to an early-stage resolution of common seemingly intractable design and management challenges that continually hinder improved (performance) outcomes of ID projects. One possible immediate policy implication would be the development of localised empirical proxies through a standardised QAE frame of reference for effective design and quality assurance of ID projects at the front-end. Such insights and perspectives would help not only uni- and multi-lateral development banks but also other ID development actors to generate requisite know-how to respond differently and appropriately to drawbacks in project quality assurance at the front-end loading of ID projects. This is of utmost importance to creating value and change since it has been established that the possibility to influence the final project outcome with real options always abounds at the highest at the front-end (see [20]; [26]).

5. CONCLUDING REMARKS

Foresight is more valuable than hindsight. Hence, designing ID projects with the requisite capacity to underpin consistent delivery of value and impact that can advance durable development in the current era of significant VUCA starts at the front-end. A sustained focus on early-stage quality assurance is required to build a culture of excellence in ID projects that can balance functional implementation with innovation[1], encourage learning, and manage knowledge and ID projects effectively. All these three elements need to work in unison to solve unique and seemingly intractable challenges and associated complexities that arise with every ID project. Hence, quality thinking and engagement from the lens of these elements and possibly from impact and sustainability at the project front-end would offer an actionable framework for improved project effectiveness as well as outcome and impact generation. This renders sound QAE in ID projects the starting and end point for futureproofing them for impact and development.

There has been an increased emphasis on development effectiveness for years now [22]. This emphasis has progressively gained strategic relevance within development institutions to materialise into an important agenda of the international community through, e.g., the 2005 Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness, and development of frameworks and operational instruments for major development interventions (see [22]). And since projects have been key to changing society and individual lives, and invaluable to leading and sustaining the value, change and impact we require to move society forward in a sustainable direction, the era of “projectisation” of society has come to stay (see, e.g., [10]). ID projects would thus continue to be instrumental in leading sustainable development in the foreseeable future. Considering both developments, the need for rethinking quality as a pivotal entry variable for ID projects to adapt systems and generate new paradigms capable of boosting robustness and excellence accords well with modern-day business and development agenda. Such new paradigms would enable ID project systems to withstand VUCAlity to improve their effectiveness in terms of both implementation and delivery and impact to, in turn, influence sustainable development priorities. Hence, such research focus has never been apposite to research agenda for the ever-learning profession and discipline of PM.

The issue of ensuring early-stage sound QAE in ID projects might seem remote. Yet, owing to the connection between projects and development, and the leadership role projects play in sustainable development, the ability of ID projects to functionally address core sustainable development priorities in the "Global South" and beyond risks being undermined by poor front-end quality loading in such project systems. One consistent menace of ID projects is poor (performance) outcomes and failure on the one hand as well as insignificant and unsustainable impact generation on the other hand. Accordingly, from a policy and practical perspective, there is a need for a shift in focus from heretofore exploration of success and failure factors, which are replete in literature to rethink and problematise such menace for redress along the lens of quality assurance at the ID project front-end. Such research focus, which would generate insights and knowledge on where and how "things must go right" at project outset has the capacity to contribute to functional and improved (performance) outcomes of ID projects. This stands to create a path forward to inform the global road to transformative and sustainable development with robust, relevant, and timely scientific evidence. Theoretically, the study would contribute to advancing knowledge on modern PM, which strongly informed by ID and underpinned by a growing and significant body of research, continues to evolve into a mature and diverse academic discipline, and move towards alignment with broader academic concepts including operations management, improvisational working practices, and evidence-based management (e.g., [31]).

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